# Flu

Flu will often get better on its own, but it can make some people seriously ill. It's important to get the flu vaccine if you're advised to.

## Symptoms of flu

Flu symptoms come on very quickly and can include:

- a sudden high temperature
- an aching body
- feeling tired or exhausted
- a dry cough
- a sore throat
- a headache
- difficulty sleeping
- loss of appetite
- diarrhoea or tummy pain
- feeling sick and being sick

The symptoms are similar for children, but they can also get pain in their ear and appear less active.

▼ Telling the difference between cold and flu

Cold (Link: www.nhs.uk/conditions/common-cold/) and flu symptoms are similar, but flu tends to be more severe.

| Flu | Cold |
|---|---|
| Appears quickly within a few hours | Appears gradually |
| Affects more than just your nose and throat | Affects mainly your nose and throat |
| Makes you feel exhausted and too unwell to carry on as normal | Makes you feel unwell, but you still feel well enough to do your normal activities |

## How to treat flu yourself

If you have flu, there are some things you can do to help get better more quickly.

### Do

- ✔ rest and sleep
- ✔ keep warm
- ✔ take paracetamol (Link: www.nhs.uk/medicines/paracetamol-for-adults/) or ibuprofen (Link: www.nhs.uk/medicines/ibuprofen-for-adults/) to lower your temperature and treat aches and pains
- ✔ give paracetamol or ibuprofen to your child if they're distressed or uncomfortable – check the packaging or leaflet to make sure the medicine is suitable for your child, or speak to a pharmacist or GP if you're not sure
- ✔ drink plenty of water to avoid dehydration (Link: www.nhs.uk/conditions/dehydration/) (your pee should be light yellow or clear)

## A pharmacist can help with flu

A pharmacist can give treatment advice and recommend flu remedies.

Do not take paracetamol and flu remedies that contain paracetamol at the same time as it's easy to take more than the recommended dose.

**Find a pharmacy (Link: https://www.nhs.uk/service-search/pharmacy/find-a-pharmacy)**

### Antibiotics

Antibiotics do not work for viral infections such as flu. GPs do not recommend antibiotics for flu because they will not relieve your symptoms or speed up your recovery.

### Ask for an urgent GP appointment or get help from NHS 111 if:

You or your child have symptoms of flu and:

- you're worried about your baby's or child's symptoms
- you're 65 or over
- you're pregnant
- you have a long-term medical condition – for example, diabetes or a condition that affects your heart, lungs, kidneys, brain or nerves
- you have a weakened immune system – for example, because of chemotherapy or HIV
- your symptoms do not improve after 7 days

You can call 111 or get help from 111 online (Link: https://111.nhs.uk/).

### Call 999 or go to A&E if you:

- get sudden chest pain
- have difficulty breathing
- start coughing up a lot of blood

Find your nearest A&E **(Link: https://www.nhs.uk/service-search/find-an-accident-and-emergency-service)**

Do not drive to A&E. Ask someone to drive you or call 999 and ask for an ambulance.

Bring any medicines you take with you.

## How to avoid spreading the flu

Flu is very infectious and easily spread to other people. You're more likely to give it to others in the first 5 days.

Flu is spread by germs from coughs and sneezes, which can live on hands and surfaces for 24 hours.

To reduce the risk of spreading flu:

- wash your hands often with warm water and soap

- cover your mouth and nose with a tissue when you cough or sneeze (if you do not have a tissue, cough or sneeze into the bend of your elbow, not into your hand)
- bin used tissues as quickly as possible

Try to stay at home and avoid contact with other people if you have a high temperature or you do not feel well enough to do your normal activities.

▼ See how to wash your hands correctly

### Video: how to wash your hands

Watch this video to find out the best way to wash your hands.

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## Flu vaccine

The flu vaccine helps protect against flu. It's safe and effective.

It's offered on the NHS every year in autumn or early winter to some adults and children at higher risk of getting seriously ill from flu.

### Find out more

Find out more about the:

- adult flu vaccine (Link: www.nhs.uk/vaccinations/flu-vaccine/), including who can get it and how
- children's flu vaccine (Link: www.nhs.uk/vaccinations/child-flu-vaccine/), including who can get it and how

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**13 flu studies in the UK** are currently looking for people like you to take part.

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